

Editorial

Mobile Phone, the unifier

I'D LIKE TO share an incident that set me thinking a little differently about the Digital Divide, especially in reference to our country. A few days ago, close to midnight, I was just about to leave my home and head to office for some late-night finishing-up work. The watchman—a 20-year-old boy!—asked me what time I would return. Concerned about him having to stay awake until I returned, I told him to go to bed. “I might return only at four in the morning, and I’ll wake you up by calling out loud.” To this he shot back, “Don’t bother shouting at that early hour—just give me a missed call.”

“Slightly taken aback” is how I would describe my reaction. It’s not surprising that my watchman owns a cell phone, really—there are plenty of stories about hawkers, auto drivers, and even beggars owning one. But what is unforeseen is that though he earns barely 2,000 rupees a month, he feels the need to spend Rs 1,800 on a second-hand phone, and also Rs 350 for a pre-paid card with a subscription to caller tunes. I later found out that his next plan is to save up a thousand rupees for a “lifetime incoming free” card.

The incident left me with two things to mull over: first, the spending habits of not just the middle-income group, but also of those belonging to the lowest of the income groups, are being redefined. Second, if increasing PC penetration can further the digital divide amongst the different income groups, increasing mobile use will, in contrast, bring them together.

The mobile phone, for me, is therefore a thing of wonder. It has the power to bridge a gap—a dangerous and ever-increasing gap so often called the Digital Divide: a gap between those with regular, effective access to digital technologies and those without. For example, there is a tremendous degree of disparity in the opportunity to access the Internet, and educational and business opportunities are tied to this access. People in countries where access to digital technologies is cheap and more pervasive, naturally gain the competitive edge.

Enter the mobile: a decade ago, India leapfrogged into the computer revolution, and a similar thing will happen now with the mass adoption of mobile telephony. It’s going to be faster this time round: back in the 1990, computers were expensive. It’s still not entirely rosy with mobile phones—like I said, con-



Deepak Ajwani Associate Editor

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nectivity has been a significant investment for my watchman—but we’re getting there. And it’s not limited to the cities—mobiles are entering even the most far-flung rural areas of India.

Change happens slowly in India. People in this country really *do* find it harder to adapt to change. But technology here has gone against the grain. We’re now adapting as fast as anyone else. We can’t say what will happen if what the much-in-the-news Bill Gates said comes true: that hardware will one day be free.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'D. Ajwani'.

editor@thinkdigit.com